2020. While LPR was somewhat lower in September 2020 compared to April 2020, the fact that the unemployment ratio fell to 7 per cent indicated that most of the over 10 crore labour who had become jobless after the lockdown had returned to work between July and September.

However, there was clear evidence of low wage distress among those who were employed. Millions are estimated to have lost salaried jobs and become casual workers. Even those who worked as casual workers earlier were reemployed at much lower wages. The spike in jobs under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) programme also indicated the lowering of worker income.

Only Two Major Schemes Accounted for the Bulk of Labour Budget until 2018–19

The Ministry of Labour and Employment (MoLE) is primarily in charge of Central government schemes for welfare of labour. In all, it operated twenty-nine schemes in 2018–19 and spent Rs 9291 crore on them.

Two schemes—the Pradhan Mantri Rozgar Protsahan Yojana (PMRPY), with expenditure of Rs 3499 crore, and government contribution to the Employees' Pension Scheme, 1995 (EPS), with an expenditure of Rs 4900 crore—accounted for a total expenditure of Rs 8399 crore, which consumed 90 per cent of the entire budget expenditure of MoLE.

There was only one other programme—the umbrella labour welfare scheme—with an outlay of over Rs 100 crore, with the expenditure on welfare schemes amounting to Rs 236.26 crore. It provides for the welfare of *beedi* workers, cine workers and labour working in mica mines, iron/chrome/manganese ore mines and limestone and dolomite mines. It also includes funds allocated for the North-east and the SC and ST components. These allocations are funded from industry-specific cesses or are mandatory allocations for SCs and STs.